

Teeth, alignment, and the jawline myth

Week 6, Lecture 2 · Looksmaxxing: Evidence-Based Softmaxxing

Autumn 2026 · Dental, oral aesthetics, and the jawline conversation

What we'll cover

- Whitening pathways: mechanism, efficacy, cost, and risk for three options
- Intrinsic versus extrinsic staining and why the distinction changes everything
- What modern orthodontics can and cannot do in adults
- Mewing: the claim, the evidence gap, and the AAO position
- Masseter hypertrophy from chewing: real effect, small magnitude, asymmetry risk
- Body-recomposition effects on jawline definition: the most evidence-based path

Whitening: what actually works and for whom

The stain classification that changes your decision

Before choosing a whitening product, identify the stain type.

Extrinsic staining: on or near the enamel surface

- Causes: coffee, tea, red wine, tobacco, some foods
- Responds to: peroxide-based products and mechanical polishing

Intrinsic staining: in the dentin layer, below the enamel

- Causes: tetracycline exposure in childhood, fluorosis, aging (dentin darkens naturally), trauma
- Does not respond to: OTC whitening strips or toothpaste
- Requires: professional tray whitening, in-office bleaching, or veneers for severe cases

"Whitening strips and toothpaste can only lift extrinsic surface stains."

Dr. Joyce Kahng DDS (2022)

Three whitening pathways compared

Whitening toothpaste:

OTC peroxide strips (10-14% hydrogen peroxide):

OTC options

- Mechanism: mild abrasives + low peroxide or PAP
 - Efficacy: surface polish only; no dentin penetration
 - Cost: low; sensitivity risk: low
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- Mechanism: peroxide diffuses through enamel to dentin
 - Efficacy: 1-2 shade improvement for extrinsic staining
 - Cost: moderate; sensitivity risk: moderate

Who should not chase whiter teeth with OTC products

Three scenarios where OTC whitening is the wrong tool.

1. **Tetracycline or fluorosis staining:** peroxide has no effect on these stain types; veneers are the clinical option.
2. **Existing crowns, veneers, or bonding:** whitening products do not change the color of dental restorations; whitening your natural teeth will create a mismatch.
3. **Severe enamel erosion or sensitivity:** peroxide worsens sensitivity in already-compromised enamel; see a dentist first.

Sensitivity from whitening is temporary in most cases but can last days to weeks at higher concentrations.

Orthodontics and the limits of alignment

What orthodontics actually does

Adult orthodontics moves teeth through the alveolar bone; it does not reshape the mandible.

- Braces and clear aligners apply controlled force to teeth
- The alveolar bone (the ridge that holds the teeth) responds by resorbing on one side and depositing on the other
- Over months to years, teeth move to the target position
- In adolescents, some orthopedic expansion of the palate is possible; in adults, this requires surgical assistance

What does not change: the shape and size of the mandible (lower jaw), the chin projection, or the gonial angle (the angle of the jaw at the corner).

Orthodontics improves occlusion, alignment, and smile aesthetics. It does not reshape the skeleton.

Realistic adult orthodontic outcomes

Adults who complete orthodontic treatment gain:

- Improved bite alignment (occlusion)
- Straighter teeth and a more even smile line
- Easier cleaning (fewer crowding gaps that trap plaque)
- In some cases, modest improvement in facial balance if the teeth were severely out of position

They do not gain:

- A wider jaw or more pronounced mandibular angle
- Forward maxillary projection from tooth movement alone
- Structural changes to any bone other than the alveolar process

Duration for comprehensive adult cases: 12-24 months. Retention is lifelong.

Mewing, masseter, and the jawline forum claims

Mewing: the claim and the evidence gap

Mewing is the practice, popularized by orthodontist Mike Mew, of holding the tongue flat against the palate to allegedly reshape the maxilla and improve facial structure in adults.

The American Association of Orthodontists reviewed the available literature and found:

- **Zero peer-reviewed studies** supporting mewing's effectiveness for reshaping the jaw or bite in adults
- The AAO noted that Mike Mew was struck from the UK dental register in 2024
- Tongue posture does influence craniofacial development in children during growth phases; there is no established mechanism for structural remodeling in a fully-developed adult skeleton

"The American Association of Orthodontists has extensively reviewed available literature and found zero peer-reviewed studies supporting mewing's effectiveness for reshaping the jaw or bite."

American Association of Orthodontists (2023)

Why mewing persists in forums

Mewing is a textbook case of the evidence inversion discussed in week one.

- Forum users post side-by-side photos attributed to years of mewing
- Photo angle, lighting, body fat changes, and maturation (for teenagers) all change jaw appearance without any structural remodeling
- The claimed mechanism (tongue pressure reshaping adult cortical bone) has no support in orthopedic literature; bone remodeling requires forces orders of magnitude greater than tongue pressure
- Mike Mew's father, John Mew, developed orthotropics for pediatric cases, which has some limited evidence; the adult extrapolation is not supported

Verdict: unfounded for adults. If you have alignment concerns, see an orthodontist.

Masseter hypertrophy: real but modest

The masseter is the large jaw-closing muscle at the angle of the jaw. It does hypertrophy with resistance training.

What chewing-based hypertrophy produces:

- A measurably larger masseter in imaging studies
- A more angular jaw appearance in some people
- The effect is present but small in absolute terms

Limits and risks:

- The effect is often **asymmetric**: people chew preferentially on one side, creating unequal growth
- Visible masseter hypertrophy is more likely in people with low body fat to begin with; fat covers the muscle
- Aggressive jaw-clenching or gum-chewing protocols can contribute to TMJ dysfunction (jaw joint pain)

Body recomposition: the honest path to jaw definition

The most evidence-supported path to a more defined jaw is the one covered in week five.

Subcutaneous fat distributes across the face and neck. Reducing total body fat through a caloric deficit and resistance training reveals underlying bone and muscle structure.

What changes as body fat decreases:

- The mandibular angle becomes more visible as buccal and submandibular fat reduces
- The neck and under-chin area becomes leaner, lengthening the visible jawline
- Masseter definition becomes visible at lower body fat percentages

Realistic timeline: visible facial changes typically accompany a body fat reduction of 5-10 percentage points, which takes 3-6 months with a consistent program.

This is the same mechanism described in the week 5 lecture on “eating for a visible jawline.”

Take-aways

1. Extrinsic staining responds to peroxide-based products; intrinsic staining (tetracycline, fluorosis, aging dentin) does not; identify which you have before spending money on whitening.
2. Adult orthodontics moves teeth through alveolar bone; it does not reshape the mandible or any other skeletal structure.
3. The AAO found zero peer-reviewed studies supporting mewing for structural change in adults; the forum evidence is not peer-reviewed and confounds body fat, aging, and photo technique.
4. Masseter hypertrophy from chewing is real but small in magnitude, often asymmetric, and only visible at low body fat percentages.
5. Reducing body fat through the program built in week five is the most evidence-supported path to improved jawline definition.

"The American Association of Orthodontists has extensively reviewed available literature and found zero peer-reviewed studies supporting mewing's effectiveness for reshaping the jaw or bite."

American Association of Orthodontists

Does Mewing Actually Reshape Your Jaw? (2023)

What's next

- **Reading:** “Dental, whitening, and the jawline myths” at [/c/looksmaxxing-26au/readings/wk06](#)
- **Section this week:** 24-hour oral hygiene cycle with partner defense; jawline claim audit
- **HW2 due this week:** Two-week skincare and grooming log
- **Week 7:** Style: fit, color, and dressing for your proportions